



Rare breed: Several players with the one-handed backhand have left an indelible mark on the sport, including (L-R) John McEnroe, Billie Jean King, Pete Sampras and Stan Wawrinka. Today, Lorenzo Musetti (below) and Diane Parry (facing page, below) are the highest-ranked players still employing the shot. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

A FADING WORK OF ART

The **one-handed backhand** may no longer be a default shot, but players who wield it continue to adapt to a game that has become faster, heavier and more baseline-oriented.



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With Stefanos Tsitsipas' loss to Ben Shelton in the round of 16 at the 2026 US Open, one of tennis' most enduring streaks came to an end.

For 149 years, at least one player with a one-handed backhand had made it to a Grand Slam semifinal every year, a legacy stretching back to the inaugural Wimbledon in 1877.

The US Open this year marked the end of that run, which, truth be told, feels like it had been coming for some time.

As tennis evolved into a baseline-heavy game, the one-handed backhand increasingly became a liability, gradually losing its relevance.

"I took a look. In the 1950s I think 97 or 98 per cent of players were playing one-handed backhands. It's literally like two or three per cent now. We are like dinosaurs going extinct," Tsitsipas said.

The ATP rankings offer a good starting point to understand how much the landscape has changed. When the first list was published on August 23, 1973, nine of the top 10 players used a one-handed backhand, Jimmy Connors being the exception.

It was an era defined by the dominant hand, with the weaker one finding little purpose beyond tossing the ball or celebrating a point. The area around the net was the primary real estate, and tennis was about finding the quickest way to close out a point.

The one-handed backhand remained prominent through the 1990s and early 2000s. But by the